

GIANTS

The Norse giants, whose proper name is jotnar (meaning “devourers”), are the gods’ greatest rivals. These giants are not like the huge, human-like and usually slow-witted ones found in fairy tales. Most jotnar are not oversized at all, and some are beautiful. Like the gods, they are not purely good or evil, and are capable of kindness as well as cruelty. They can also be creative – the cosmos was made by the first giant, Ymir.

GIANTS AND GIANTESSES

There are three main types of giant, who live in their own worlds within the cosmos. There are Frost Giants, Mountain Giants, and Fire Giants. The Fire Giants are led by Surtr and include Loki in their ranks. All giants are destined to fight the gods at Ragnarök.

It was a Mountain Giant who bet the Aesir that he could build a wall around Asgard. It was only Loki’s trickery that caused him to fail.



Mimir is the wisest of all the creatures of the cosmos and became counsellor to Odin. He might be a giant or a god.

GIANT BEASTS

Though not usually classed as jotnar themselves, many of the huge creatures of Norse mythology are born from giants. These include the wolf Fenrir and the serpent Jörmungandr – created by Loki and the giantess Angrboda.

Nidhogg is a malicious serpent-dragon who constantly gnaws at one of Yggdrasil’s roots as well as the dishonourable dead in Niflheim.

Tossed by Odin into the sea to die, Jörmungandr grew long enough to encircle Midgard. It harboured a hatred for the Aesir – especially Thor.

